

TAB 29



Board of Education Report

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In Control: Board of Education

Dr. Rivas - Honoring Robert Vargas: Advancing Arts Education, Cultural Identity, and Community Expression for the Next Generation (Res-058-25/26) (For Action May 12, 2026)

Whereas, Robert Vargas, Born and raised in Boyle Heights, is a renowned Los Angeles muralist whose work reflects the cultural identity, resilience, and lived experiences of communities across the city;

Whereas, From a young age, he began painting murals and developed a lifelong commitment to public art as a powerful form of storytelling that uplifts culture, history, and community voices;

Whereas, His large-scale, freehand murals across Los Angeles and internationally have helped define the visual landscape of neighborhoods such as Downtown Los Angeles, Boyle Heights, and Little Tokyo, making art accessible to the public and rooted in place;

Whereas, Mr. Vargas is an alumnus of the Los Angeles County High School for the Arts, a public arts high school that has cultivated generations of young artists and reflects the importance of arts education within public systems;

Whereas, His journey from public education to international recognition demonstrates to students that their creativity, voice, and cultural identity are powerful assets that can shape careers, communities, and the broader world;

Whereas, Through his work, Mr. Vargas has consistently uplifted historically marginalized communities, centering narratives of Black, Latino, Indigenous, Asian, and immigrant communities whose stories are often underrepresented in traditional spaces;

Whereas, In addition to his artistic contributions, Mr. Vargas has engaged in community-centered efforts and collaborations that support youth inspiration, cultural pride, and access to creative expression;

Whereas, Mr. Vargas has brought his art directly into educational spaces through school-based murals, including a planned mural at Mendez High School, where the school library will be named the Robert Vargas Library and Media Center, as well as murals at Soto Street Elementary School and Roosevelt High School, helping transform campuses into spaces that reflect student identity, culture, and community pride;

Whereas, Mr. Vargas has also conducted live painting demonstrations and artistic engagements at numerous Los Angeles Unified School District schools, providing students with direct exposure to artistic practice, mentorship, and creative expression;

Whereas, Public art, including murals on school campuses, serves as a powerful platform for student voice, storytelling, and expressions of identity and justice, helping to create welcoming, affirming, and

culturally responsive environments for students and families;

Whereas, The District’s commitment to educational equity includes expanding access to arts education, fostering student creativity, strengthening Linked Learning and career technical education pathways in the arts and creative industries, and supporting place-based learning opportunities;

Whereas, Recognizing artists like Mr. Vargas provides an opportunity to inspire students to explore artistic pathways, engage in civic expression, and understand the role of art in shaping community identity and advancing social justice; and

Whereas, The City of Los Angeles declared September 8 as “Robert Vargas Day,” the County of Los Angeles dedicated January 24 as “Robert Vargas Day,” and Robert Vargas Square in Boyle Heights further recognizes his lasting cultural and artistic contributions across the region; now, therefore, be it

Resolved, That the Governing Board of the Los Angeles Unified School District honors Robert Vargas for his ongoing contributions to art, culture, and the communities of Los Angeles, and proclaims May 12 of each year as Robert Vargas Day in the District;

Resolved further, That the Board directs the Superintendent to encourage schools to incorporate lessons on muralism, public art, and culturally relevant artistic expression, highlighting the work and impact of Mr. Vargas;

Resolved further, That such efforts may include student art projects, partnerships with local artists and community-based organizations, and opportunities for students to engage in creative expression that reflects their identities and communities, including school-based mural projects where appropriate;

Resolved further, That May 12, “Robert Vargas Day” in the District, shall serve as a Districtwide celebration of the arts and a call to action for schools to engage students in art projects, deepen learning about the arts, and expose students to careers in the arts and creative industries through activities across classrooms and campuses; and, be it finally

Resolved, That the District affirms its commitment to advancing arts education and public art as essential components of a well-rounded education, including supporting partnerships, elevating student-led creative expression, and expanding culturally responsive artistic opportunities that reflect and uplift the identities and lived experiences of students and families across Los Angeles.